

I see no reason why we can't make a London out of Kolkata. We have the Hooghly, the forest, the mountains, the sea... What else do we need?

MAMATA BANERJEE
Trinamool Congress Leader



SUVASHIS MULLICK

The Home Stretch

- South Kolkata is the VVIP seat in West Bengal from where Mamata Banerjee is seeking her second hat-trick. She won from here in 1991 and 1996 as a Congress candidate, and in 1998, 1999 and 2004 as a Trinamool candidate. In 2004, she defeated Congress's Nafisa Ali and CPI(M)'s Rabin Deb.
- The constituency, which is mainly a residential area consisting of many planned townships and posh elite areas, has 15 lakh voters.
- CPI(M)'s Rabin Deb and BJP's Jyotsna Banerjee are Mamata's rivals this time.
- Five new Assembly segments have been added after delimitation, including the port area and Behala, with a sizeable Muslim population while Hindu middle class areas like Tollygunj have been excluded.
- Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi held this seat earlier.

here in my constituency but I will tie the communists to this place. They are giving it their all to defeat me. Let them focus only on South Kolkata while I campaign elsewhere." At meeting after meeting, her voice grows, finishing with a loud jury-like verdict against the reds. "The worst thing about this Government is that it is packed with liars. How can the chief minister support the making of the campaign CD which gives a totally

wrong one-sided picture of the Tapasi Malik case? How can they say that her parents killed her when the entire state knows otherwise?" Not to miss a good chance to drive the nail home, she has brought Malik's parents with her. The father takes the mike and like a good, almost trained speaker raves and rants against the Communists, breaking into sobs and weeping at tragic points. "Budda *babu* (Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya) is

a know-all. But I am afraid he doesn't know the law. I have studied law and have even stood in courtrooms a couple of times. How can he give a clean chit to the killers of Tapasi when we have gone on appeal? We will not rest till we get justice," she thunders.

Suddenly, Banerjee's *bete noire* for many years, Jyoti Basu, becomes a subject of sympathy. "Jyoti *babu* wanted the Nano case to be solved. But does anybody in the party care for his advice any longer?" she asks. "We were never against the Nano project. The state Government is to blame. They went against the accord reached in the presence of the governor. But let me assure you, we have lost nothing with the Nano going to Gujarat. Why doesn't the Government look into our very own Hind Motors which is so sick that employees do not have the means to live a decent life?"

Then she reveals a secret. "Allow me to let you on to a secret. The CPI(M) now has plans to mortgage the Nano land in Singur to a Chinese company. I know its name but I am not saying. The cat will soon be out of the bag." In interview after interview, she has already been set up as the next chief minister by a section of the media. She takes this all too gleefully but with a slight dash of shyness. "This is a Lok Sabha election. But we have to prepare ourselves for the bigger Assembly battle. It's natural for local issues to be debated in parliamentary polls. But for me, more important is the fact that the Left's role in Parliament should be diminished so that they can't browbeat us here," she says.

Her latest dream is to make Kolkata another London and all of North Bengal a Switzerland. "Why not? I have been to these places abroad and I see no reason why we can't make a London out of Kolkata. We have the Hooghly, the forest, the mountains, the sea... what else do we need? Buddha *babu* sleeps while he travels. I don't and when I see the natural bounty, I feel sad as to why we can't make Bengal the best." Banerjee shakes her head. "Foresight, foresight... that's what we need..." And the votes, of course. ■